Reading a viz → Build manually → Build with AI → Write interpretation → AI interpretation → Spot disruption

How to read a FASTR visualization

Reference · Visualizations & Interpretation · ~10 min

WHAT THIS HANDOUT IS

A short reference you'll use over and over. A chart is a question rendered as a picture — before you build one, or ask the AI for one, you need to be able to *read* one.
Keep it next to you during the next activities.

The six-step framework

Use this every time you open a chart, whether you built it or someone else did:

Step	Ask yourself
1. What indicator?	What health metric is shown? (ANC1, ANC4, vaccination coverage, …)
2. What level & period?	National, regional, district, facility? What time range?
3. What is being compared?	Actual vs. expected? District vs. district? Change over time?
4. Read the values	What's the magnitude — high, low, changing?
5. What stands out?	Trends, gaps, spikes, disruptions, anomalies
6. So what?	What does this mean for service delivery? What action would it prompt?

Tip: Always check the legend, axis labels, and any footnotes *before* you start interpreting. Misreading the y-axis is the single most common mistake.

Choosing the right chart type

Different questions call for different charts. Two patterns cover most FASTR outputs:

- **Line chart** — best for **trends over time**. One or two indicators, monthly values. Easy to see direction.
- **Heatmap** — best for **comparing many places at once**. Districts × indicators in one view. Easy to spot which places are off-pattern.

When you want to see...	Use
How one indicator changed over the last 12 months	Line chart
How 25 districts compare on the same indicator	Heatmap
Two indicators on the same time axis	Line chart (dual series)
One indicator, one period, across a few districts	Bar chart

When in doubt: start with a line chart for one indicator, or a heatmap for many.

Quick test — try the six steps

Open the slide deck or report you've been working on with the AI Assistant. With a teammate, walk through the six steps on each chart in it. Notice where you slow down — that's usually where a chart is missing a label, or where the question it's trying to answer isn't clear yet.

What's next

You'll build your own visualization next — first manually, then with the AI Assistant. Both end with this same six-step framework to interpret what you produced.